14. Formation of State of Maharashtra

After India gained independence, there was demand on large scale for the reconstruction of states on linguistic basis. In Maharashtra also the demand for state of Marathi speaking people led to 'Samyukta Maharashtra Movement' from 1946 onwards. Through various changing circumstances the movement progressed and finally on 1 May 1960 the state of Maharashtra came to be formed.

Background : From the beginning of 20th century, many scholars had begun to express the thoughts on unification of Marathi speaking people. In 1911, the British Government had to suspend the partition of Bengal. On this background, N.C.Kelkar wrote that 'the entire Marathi speaking population should be under one dominion'. In 1915, Lokmanya Tilak had demanded the reconstruction of a state based on language. But during that period the issue of independence of India was more important, hence this issue remained aside.

On 12 May 1946, in the Sahitya Sammelan at Belgaon, an important resolution regarding Samyukta Maharashtra was passed.

Samyukta Maharashtra Parishad : On 28 July, 'Maharashtra Ekikaran Parishad' was called at Mumbai. Shankarrao Dev was its president. It passed a resolution that all Marathi speaking regions should be included in one state. This should also include Marathi speaking regions of Mumbai, Central provinces as well as Marathwada and Gomantak.

Dar Commission : On 17 June 1948, Dr. Rajendra Prasad, the President of Constituent Assembly established the 'Dar Commission' under the chairmanship of Justice S.K.Dar, for forming linguistic provinces. On 10 December 1948, the report of Dar Commission was published but the issue remained unsolved.

JVP Committee (Three Ministers Committee) : To study the conditions of creating linguistic provinces, the Congress appointed a committee on 29 December 1948. It included Jawaharlal Nehru, Vallabhbhai Patel and Pattabhisitaramayya. It is known by the initials of these members as 'JVP Committee'. The report suggested that Congress accepts the concept of linguistic state in principle but the time was not proper for it. Severe response was seen throughout Maharashtra against this report. During that time Senapati Bapat organised rallies for awakening of people.

Acharya Atre got passed the proposal of Samyukta Maharashtra with Mumbai in the Mumbai Municipal Corporation. It got passed by 50 against 35 votes. Due to it, the desire that Mumbai should be included in Maharashtra was proven.

Commission for Reconstruction of States : Government of India appointed a 'Commission for Reconstruction of States' on 29 December 1953, under the Chairmanship of Justice Fazal Ali. This commission presented their proposal on 10 October 1955. This proposal advocated for creation of bilingual Mumbai State.

Nagpur Pact : Marathi people of all regions should resolve to make one state was the purpose of signing the Nagpur Pact in 1953. According to this pact, Samyukta Maharashtra was formed

including Western Maharashtra and Vidarbha along with Marathwada. In 1956, as per the ammendment of the Constitution, Article 371 (2) was included in it. According to the Nagpur Pact assurance was given regarding equitable financial provision for developmental work, ample finance for technical and vocational education, provision of state government services in particular regions in accordance with the population and Assembly Session once in a year should be held in Nagpur etc.

The struggle of marathi speaking people for formation of Maharashtra with Mumbai had begun. A huge meeting was held on Kamgar Maidan in Mumbai. At that time Shankarrao Dev said, 'We will oppose the seperation of Mumbai from Maharashtra upto our last breath'. The emotions and demands of the people took the form of public agitation. Women also spontaneously started participating in it. Sumatibai Gore, Ismat Chugtai, Durga Bhagwat, Tara Reddi, Charusheela Gupte, Kamalatai More, Sultana Johari and many such women took part in the agitation.

On 7 November 1955, there was meeting of labours. Various Labour Organisations, Communists, Praja Socialists, Socialists, Peasants and workers Party, Janasangh etc. all these political parties participated in it. Comrade Shripad Amrut Dange presided over it. Here S.M.Joshi proposed a resolution that Samyukta Maharashtra, with Mumbai and Vidarbha, should be created.

Beginning of actual conflict : Discontent among the Marathi speaking people was growing. A grand march led by Senapati Bapat was taken to Vidhan Sabha. Morarji Desai was the Chief Minister at that time. The government declared a ban. The police started lathi charge and used tear gas. On that evening an open meeting was conducted on Kamgar Maidan with a mob of around 50 thousand. Comrade Dange guided the people. To accelerate the struggle for the Samyukta Maharashtra Movement, on 21 November 1955 decision of one day token strike was taken.

P. K. Atre

Establishment of Samyukta Maharashtra Samiti : The issue of the demand of the Marathi speaking people started becoming complicated. Discontent spread throughout the state. On 6 February 1956, a meeting was conducted under the Chairmanship of Keshavrao Jedhe at Tilak Smarak Mandir in Pune. The Samiti declared its Executive Council. Comrade Shripad Amrut Dange as the President. Dr.T.R.Naravane as Vice President and S.M.Joshi as General Secretary were selected. G.T.Madkholkar, Acharya P.K.Atre, Madhu Dandavate, Prabodhankar Keshav Thackeray, Y.K. Souni played important role in establishing the Samiti. At the same time Senapati Bapat, Krantisinh Nana Patil,

S.M.Joshi

Prabodhankar Thackeray

Do you know ?

Lokshahir Annabhau Sathe

Shahir Amar Sheikh

Shahir D.N.Gavankar

Contribution of Marathi newspapers and Shahirs : In this movement the role of newspapers was important. Prabodhan, Kesari, Sakal, Navakal, Navyug, Prabhat many such newspapers worked for awakening of the people. Acharya Atre started the 'Maratha' newspaper which played an important role in Samyukta Maharashtra Movement. Balasaheb Thackeray took up the pen name 'Mavla' and drew caricatures to make the movement comprehensive.

Lokshahir Annabhau Sathe, Shahir Amar Sheikh and Shahir D.N.Gavankar through their writings aroused public awakening on a large scale.

Lalji Pendse, Ahilyabai Rangnekar contributed immensely to the Samyukta Maharashtra movement. They spread the movement to rural parts of Maharashtra.

When it was clear that Mumbai will not be included in Maharashtra, at that time there arouse a huge public agitation. In this movement 106 people became martyrs in the firing opened by the State Government. In memory of the 106 sons of Maharashtra who became martyr for formation of Samyukta Maharashtra, the 'Hutatma Smarak' was erected in Mumbai near Flora Fountain.

On 1 November 1956, Bilingual Mumbai State came into existence. Later in 1957, Loksabha, Vidhan Sabha and Mumbai Municipal Corporation elections were held. Samyukta Maharashtra Samiti got grand success. These results made it clear that the voters were against bilingual state and in favour of Samyukta Maharashtra.

The unveiling of statue of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj mounted on horse on Pratapgad was to be done at the hands of Prime Minister Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru on 30 November 1957. At that time Samyukta Maharashtra Samiti decided to make huge demonstration under the leadership of Bhai Madhavrao Bagal. Leaders like S.M.Joshi, N.G.Gore, Jayantrao Tilak, P.K.Atre, Uddhavrao Patil were present. Severe demonstrations were made at Pasarni Ghat and Poladpur. The Samiti succeeded in making Pandit Nehru aware of the conditions as well as of the sentiments of the Marathi speaking people.

Uddhavrao Patil

The Central Governement favoured

the making of Maharashtra due to the agitation led by Samyukta Maharashtra Samiti. At this instance, Indira Gandhi , President of Congress supported the Samyukta Maharashtra movement. The Central Government consented the two linguistic states- Maharashtra and Gujarat. In April 1960, the Parliament passed the Mumbai Reorganisation Act. According to this Act, Maharashtra State was formed on 1 May 1960.

Yashwantrao Chavan

At the dawn of 1 May 1960, in the special ceremony at Raj Bhavan, on occasion of Labour Day, Pandit Nehru officially announced the formation of Maharashtra State. Yashwantrao Chavan accepted the responsibility as first Chief Minister of Maharashtra.

Exercise

1. Rewrite the statements by choosing the appropriate options.

(1) The State of ..... was formed on 1 May 1960.
(a) Goa (b) Karnataka
(c) Andhra Pradesh (d) Maharashtra

(2) ..... put forth the proposal of Samyukta Maharashtra with Mumbai in the Mumbai Municipal Corporation.
(a) G.T.Madkholkar
(b) Acharya Atre
(c) D.V.Potdar
(d) Shankarrao Dev

(3) ..... accepted the responsibility as first Chief Minister of Maharashtra.
(a) Yashvantrao Chavan
(b) Prithviraj Chavan
(c) Shankarrao Chavan
(d) Vilasrao Deshmukh

2. Explain the following statements with reasons.

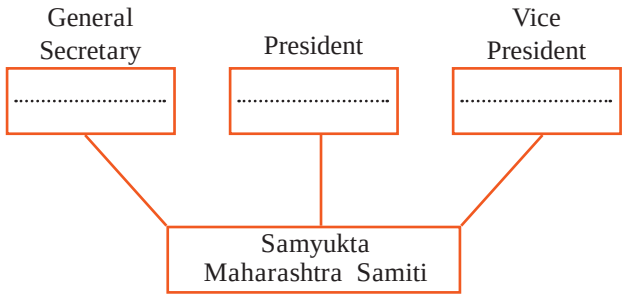
(1) Samyukta Maharashtra Samiti came to be established.

(2) The role of newspapers was important in Samyukta Maharashta Movement.

3. Write short notes.

(1) Samyukta Maharashtra Parishad
(2) Contribution of Samyukta Maharashtra Samiti.

4. Complete the following diagram.



Project

Collect information about the personalities who greatly contributed to the formation of Maharashtra and prepare a project based on it with the help of your teachers.

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